

Stand & Deliver

Builds: Communication & Presentation

A turnkey weekly routine for building the reps students never got: standing up, looking up, and explaining their thinking from a single note card.

Builds: Communication & Presentation **Grade band:** 6–12 (adaptation notes for grades 3–5 and college/CTE below)
Time: A recurring weekly cycle — draw a topic Monday, prep midweek, deliver Friday — run for ~6+ weeks across a term, not a one-and-done unit **Format:** Small-group delivery (not whole-class), gradually released from a planning scaffold to fully student-owned

Why this unit

This is one of the missing reps from the keynote. Our students freeze when asked to stand and explain something — and we call it stage fright, but it isn't. It's that they were never given the practice. They've presented maybe a handful of times in their whole school career, almost always with a slide deck doing the talking for them. The note card itself feels foreign: a few cues, look up, explain it in your own words. That craft is exactly what's gone. This routine fixes it the only way it can be fixed — through volume, in low stakes, every single week. And it trains the one thing AI can never do for them: stand in front of another human and explain their own work and their own reasoning out loud.

Learning objective

By the end of the term, **students can stand in front of a small group and clearly explain a topic for two minutes, working from note cards as a guide rather than a script** — planning, prepping, and delivering without a teacher check-in.

Materials & prep

Teacher prep (~15 min the first week, ~2 min after):

- Build a **topic deck** of cards that rotate through three lanes: **personal** (explain something you know well — a hobby, a skill, a place), **academic** (explain a concept from another class — photosynthesis, the water cycle, a math idea, a moment in history), and **professional** (explain a process or decision — how you'd plan an event, how you decided which of two options is better). Aim for ~6 cards per lane so a student rarely repeats. Keep them in an envelope or a hat.
- Print **blank index cards** (3×5) — students get one per week. The constraint is the point: one card, cues only.
- Print the **Student Handout** (below) once per student for their folder — it holds the note-card template *and* the peer-feedback form.
- Decide your small groups (4–5 students each). Keep groups stable for a few weeks so trust builds, then reshuffle.

Students need: their handout, one blank index card per week, something to write with, and a simple self-reflection log (a half-sheet or a section of their notebook).

The arc at a glance

The same weekly cycle repeats. What changes is how much scaffolding you provide — it withdraws over the term.

Beat	When	Focus	~Time
Draw	Monday	Each student draws a topic card from the rotating lane of the week	~5 min
Prep	Midweek	Build the talk on ONE note card — cues only, no script, no slides	~10–15 min
Deliver	Friday	Two-minute talk to a small group; peers give one structured note; speaker logs a reflection	~25–30 min for the round

Phase of the term	Weeks	What the teacher provides	What the student owns
Scaffolded	~1–2	The labeled note-card template (hook, main point, example, close)	Filling in the template, delivering
Released	~3–4	Blank card only — no template	Designing their own card structure
Owned	~5–6+	Just the topic on Monday — no check-in	Planning, prepping, and delivering fully solo

Step-by-step sequence

Monday — Draw the topic (~5 min)

- **(2 min) Rotate the lane.** Announce the week's lane (personal / academic / professional) so the whole class is working the same muscle. Lanes cycle week to week.
- **(3 min) Draw and lock in.** Each student draws a card from the deck. They write their topic at the top of this week's blank index card and put it in their folder. That's it for Monday — the talk happens Friday, so there's a built-in runway.

Midweek — Prep on one card (~10–15 min, or assigned as homework)

- **Early weeks (scaffolded):** Students use the **note-card template** from the handout to fill in four labeled cues — hook, main point, example, close. Remind them: these are *cues*, not sentences. If they can read it word-for-word, it's too much.
- **Middle weeks (released):** Remove the template. Hand out a blank card. Students decide their own structure — how many cues, what order, what to leave off. Some will over-write at first; let the Friday feedback teach them.
- **Late weeks (owned):** No teacher touch at all. The topic was drawn Monday; planning and prep are entirely theirs. You don't see the card until Friday.
- Hold the line on the rule every week: **one card, cues only — no slides, no full script, no phone.**

Friday — Deliver to the small group (~25–30 min)

- **(3 min) Set the room.** Students get into their standing small groups. Restate the job: *"Two minutes. Stand. Look up. Explain it from your card. You will not get through it by reading."*
- **(18–20 min) Rounds.** Within each group, students take turns: one stands and delivers for two minutes while the others listen. Keep it tight — a 5-person group runs in ~12–15 minutes of talk plus feedback. You circulate; you don't run it.
- **(5 min) One structured note each.** After each talk, every listener gives the speaker **one** piece of feedback using the peer-feedback form: *What was the clearest moment? What would help you follow along even better?* Two questions, one note — not a critique pile-on.

- **(3 min) Reflection log.** Before they sit down for good, each speaker writes two lines in their self-reflection log: one thing that worked, one thing to try next week. This is how they track their own growth across the term — the reps add up and they can see it.

A topic-card bank you can use

Here's the deck so you don't have to invent it. Print this page, cut the lines into strips, drop them in three labeled envelopes — one per lane — and draw from the week's lane on Monday. Every prompt is written age-flexible (6–12): a younger student explains the simple version, an older one explains the *why* underneath it. Add or swap your own as your class finds its rhythm.

Personal — *explain something you know or care about*

- Explain how to do something you're good at, step by step (a game, a sport, a craft, a recipe).
- Explain a place that matters to you and why someone should care about it.
- Explain a hobby or collection to someone who's never heard of it.
- Explain how to take care of a pet, a plant, or something you're responsible for.
- Explain a song, show, or book you love — and what makes it actually good, not just fun.
- Explain a skill you taught yourself and how you figured it out.
- Explain a tradition in your family or community and where it comes from.
- Explain something you changed your mind about, and what changed it.
- Explain a problem you solved recently and how you got through it.
- Explain something most people get wrong about a thing you know well.

Academic — *explain a concept from another class*

- Explain the water cycle — and why it never runs out.
- Explain photosynthesis like the plant is doing a job with a purpose.
- Explain how to solve one kind of math problem, and *why* the steps work, not just what they are.
- Explain a moment in history and why it still matters today.
- Explain what a fraction (or a percent, or a ratio) really means with a real-world example.
- Explain how a food chain or ecosystem stays in balance — and what happens when it doesn't.
- Explain the difference between two things people mix up (weather vs. climate, mass vs. weight, a fact vs. an opinion).
- Explain what causes something in nature (tides, seasons, day and night, rain).
- Explain a vocabulary word or idea from a class so clearly a younger kid would get it.
- Explain a science experiment or a book you read and what it was really about.

Professional — *explain a process, decision, or how something works*

- Explain how you'd plan an event — and the order you'd do things in.
 - Explain how you decided between two options, and why you picked the one you did.
 - Explain how a job you find interesting actually works, day to day.
 - Explain how something gets made or how a service gets delivered, start to finish.
 - Explain how you'd spend a fixed budget on a goal, and what trade-off you'd make.
 - Explain how a team should split up a task so it gets done well.
 - Explain how you'd fix a problem if the first plan didn't work.
 - Explain how a tool, app, or machine works well enough that someone could use it.
 - Explain how you'd handle a tough situation with a customer, teammate, or classmate.
 - Explain a rule or process at school or work and why it exists.
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Student handout (copy-ready)

Stand & Deliver — Your Weekly Two Minutes

Every week you draw a topic on Monday and explain it to your small group for **two minutes** on Friday. The rules never change: **stand up, look up, one note card, cues only**. No slides. No script. If you can read your card word-for-word, you wrote too much.

YOUR NOTE CARD (early weeks — use this template; later weeks — design your own)

Write only a few words on each line. These are cues to *remind* you, not sentences to *read*.

- **HOOK** — the one line that makes them want to listen (*a question, a surprising fact, why this matters*)
- **MAIN POINT** — the single thing you want them to walk away understanding
- **EXAMPLE** — one concrete example, story, or step that makes it click
- **CLOSE** — how you land it (*the takeaway, the "so what"*)

Test before Friday: can you give the whole talk just by glancing at these cues and looking up the rest of the time? If you're reading, cut words until you can't.

PEER-FEEDBACK FORM (fill one out for each speaker in your group)

Speaker: _____ Topic: _____

1. **What was the clearest moment?** (*the part where you followed along easily — name it specifically*)

2. **What would help you follow along even better?** (*one helpful idea — not a list*)

YOUR REFLECTION LOG (two lines, right after you deliver)

- One thing that worked this week: _____
- One thing to try next week: _____

What proficient looks like (teacher look-fors)

- The student **looks up** — eye contact, not a face buried in the card.
- The card holds **cues, not sentences**; they're speaking in their own words, not reading.
- The talk has a **clear arc** (hook → point → example → close) and lands **within the two minutes**.
- When the lane is academic or professional, they **explain the why** — the reasoning behind a choice, not just a description of the thing.
- Their reflection log shows they're **acting on last week's note**, not repeating the same stumble.

Assessment

Score with [toolkit/rubrics.md](#) — the **Communication & Presentation** cluster. No separate grade required; lay it over the Friday talks students are already giving. Three competency statements carry this routine:

- *"...present work to a group clearly and within time."*

- "...use note cards as a guide, not a script."
- "...explain the reasoning behind their decisions, not just the output."

Proficient = the student does it independently this week — looks up, speaks from cues, finishes on time, and explains a decision unprompted. **Advanced** = the student *tailors the talk to this particular audience, anticipates and answers a likely question, and weaves the decision rationale throughout* rather than tacking it on.

Because the routine repeats, the best assessment artifact is the trend: pull a student's reflection logs across the term and read them next to the rubric. Growth shows up in the stack.

The rubric for this unit

Lay these competency rows over the Friday talks students are already giving — no separate assignment. **Proficient** is the target (demonstrated and independent); **Advanced** means the student extends the skill unprompted.

Communication & Presentation

The student can...	Not Yet	Approaching	Proficient	Advanced
...present work to a group clearly and within time.	Reads directly from a screen or sheet with no eye contact; audience cannot follow the explanation.	Makes occasional eye contact and has a loose structure but loses the thread partway through.	Looks at the audience, follows a clear arc (what I did, why, what I learned), and finishes within time.	Tailors the arc to this specific audience, anticipates a likely question, and lands the close memorably.
...use note cards as a guide, not a script.	Either reads every word verbatim or improvises with no structure at all.	Uses notes but drifts into reading them word-for-word when nervous.	Glances at note cards to stay on track but speaks in their own words; cards hold cues, not sentences.	Uses a minimal cue system that keeps eye contact nearly continuous and recovers smoothly from any stumble.
...explain the reasoning behind their decisions, not just the output.	Describes what the project is without explaining why any choices were made.	Names a choice or two when prompted but cannot explain the reasoning unprompted.	Volunteers the reasoning behind at least one key decision and can answer "why did you do it that way?" without hesitation.	Weaves decision rationale throughout the presentation, names trade-offs considered, and invites pushback.

Gradual release across the term

	Teacher provides	Student provides
Scaffolded (~weeks 1-2)	The labeled note-card template; reminders on cues-not-script; structured prep time in class	Fills in the template; delivers two minutes
Released (~weeks 3-4)	A blank card only — no template; lighter check-ins	Designs their own card structure; delivers
Owned (~weeks 5-6+)	Just the topic, drawn Monday — no check-in at all	Plans, preps, and delivers fully solo; self-tracks via the log

The goal is that by the end of the term, the whole cycle — draw, prep, stand, explain — runs without you. The reps did the teaching.

Differentiation & adaptation

- **Grades 3–5:** Keep all topics in the **personal** lane (explain a favorite game, animal, or place). Shorten to **one minute**, and keep the template the whole time — don't release it. The card can be a sentence stem ("My topic is... The most important thing is... For example...").
- **College / CTE:** Pull topics from their **field** — explain a clinical decision, a code architecture choice, a budget trade-off. Require the professional lane to name a trade-off and invite a question from the group, pushing toward Advanced. Reshuffle groups to simulate presenting to unfamiliar stakeholders.
- **Multilingual learners / IEPs:** Allow more cues on the card and a slightly longer runway; provide cue *stems* on the template ("My main point is...", "One example is..."). Let them deliver to a group of two or three first, then scale up as confidence builds.
- **Quiet or anxious students:** The small group *is* the accommodation — this is why it isn't a whole-class presentation. Let nervous students go later in the round so they see a few models first.

Common pitfalls

- **Letting the card become a script.** The moment cards have full sentences, students read and stop looking up. Walk the room and quietly tell over-writers to cut. The constraint is the lesson.
- **Letting slides creep back in.** "Can I just show one slide?" No. The whole point is the human standing and explaining without a deck doing the work.
- **Running it whole-class.** It feels more impressive, but it kills the rep count and spikes the stakes. Small groups give more turns, more often, with less fear.
- **Skipping the reflection log.** Without it, the weeks blur and students can't see their own growth — and you lose your best assessment artifact.
- **Releasing the scaffold too fast.** Hold the template until the structure is automatic; pulling it in week two leaves shakier students stranded.

The low-lift version (if you have no room for the full routine)

You don't need a standing weekly routine to start. Take an assignment you already give and bolt on **the 90-second stand-and-explain on one note card** — call on a few students to stand and explain what they did, why they made a key choice, and what they'd do differently, working only from a single card. That's the [Communication & Presentation weave-in](#) move — this entire routine compressed into 90 seconds you add to work you were already assigning. Do it often enough and you've quietly built the reps anyway.